

cassava and maize, and of palm wine, but they throw themselves into a peculiar state of intoxication, we might almost say of madness, by the use of the powder of *niopo* *. They gather the long pods of a mimosacea, which we have made known by the name of *acacia niopo* †, cut them into pieces, moisten them, and cause them to ferment. When the softened seeds begin to grow black, they are kneaded like a paste, mixed with some flour of cassava and lime procured from the shell of a helix, and the whole mass is exposed to a very brisk fire, on a grate of hard wood. The hardened paste takes the form of small cakes. When it is to be used, it is reduced to a fine powder, and placed on a dish five or six inches wide. The Otomac holds this dish, which has a handle, in his right hand, while he inhales the *niopo* by the nose, through a forked bone of a bird, the two extremities of which are applied to the nostrils. This bone, without

* In Maypure, *nupa*; the missionaries say *ñopo*.

† It is an acacia with very delicate leaves, and not an inga, as Mr. *Willdenow* has said by mistake. (*Spec. Plant.*, vol. iv, pl. 2, p. 1027.) We brought home another species of mimosacea (the *chiga* of the Otomacs, and the *sepa* of the Maypures), that yields seeds, the flour of which is eaten at Uruana like cassava. From this flour the *chiga bread* is prepared, which is so common at Cunariche, and on the banks of the Lower Oroonoko. The *chiga* is a species of *inga*, and I know of no other mimosacea, that can supply the place of the cerealia.

which the Otómac believes that he could not take this kind of snuff, is seven inches long : it appeared to me to be the leg bone of a large sort of plover (*échassier*). I sent the *niopo*, and all this singular apparatus, to Mr. de Fourcroy at Paris. The *niopo* is so stimulating, that the smallest portions of it produce a violent sneezing in those, who are not accustomed to it's use. Father Gumilla says *, “ This diabolical powder of the Otomacs, furnished by an arborescent tobacco-plant, intoxicates them by the nostrils (*emboracha por las narices*), deprives them of reason for some hours, and renders them furious in battle.” However varied may be the family of the leguminous plants in the chemical and medical properties of their seeds, juices, and roots, we cannot believe, from what we know hitherto of the group of mimosaceæ, that it is principally the pod of the *acacia niopo*, that imparts the stimulant power to the snuff of the Otomacs. This power is owing, no doubt, to the lime freshly calcined. We have shown above, that the mountaineers of the Andes of Popayan, and the Guajiros who wander between the lake of Maracaybo and the Rio la Hacha, are also fond of swallowing lime as a stimulant, to augment the secretion of the spittle and the gastric juice.

* *Orinoco illust.*, vol. i, p. 202.

In sending to Europe the complicated apparatus, which the Otomacs employ in order to inhale the powder of *niopo*, I directed the attention of the learned to an analogous custom, which Mr. de la Condamine observed among the natives of the Upper Maragnon. The Omaguas, whose name is rendered celebrated by the expeditions attempted in search of Dorado, have the same dish, and the same hollow bone of a bird, by which they convey to their nostrils their powder of *curupa*. The seed that yields this powder is no doubt also a mimosacea; for the Otomacs, according to Father Gili, denote even now, at the distance of one hundred and sixty leagues from the Amazon, the *acacia niopo* by the name of *curupa* *. Since the geographical researches, which I have recently made on the theatre of the exploits of Philip von Hutten, and on the real situation of the province of Papamene †, or of the Omaguas, the probability of an ancient communication between the Otomacs of the Oroonoko and the Omaguas of the Maragnon has become more interesting and more probable. The former came from the Meta, perhaps from the country between the Meta and the Guaviare; the latter assert, that they descended

* Gili, vol. i, p. 201. *La Condamine, Voyage à l'Amazone*, p. 62.

† See above, p. 319, 323, 340.

in great numbers * to the Maragnon by the Rio Japura, coming from the eastern declivity of the Andes of New Grenada. Now, it is precisely between the Guayavero, which joins the Guaviare, and the Caqueta, which takes lower down the name of Japura, that the country of the Omagua appears to be situate, of which the adventurers of Coro and Tocuyo in vain attempted the conquest. There is no doubt a striking contrast between the present barbarism of the Otomacs, and the ancient civilization of the Omaguas; but all parts of the latter nation were not perhaps alike advanced in civilization, and the example of tribes fallen into complete barbarism are unhappily but too common in the history of our species. Another point of resemblance may be remarked between the Otomacs and the Omaguas. Both of these nations are celebrated among all the tribes of the Oroonoko and the Amazon for the frequent use which they make of *caoutchouc*, or the inspissated milk of the euphorbiaceæ and the urticeæ.

* I do not admit, with Mr. de la Condamine, that the whole nation of the Omaguas came from the north. (See the learned researches of Mr. Vater on the ancient seats of that powerful people, tolerably advanced in civilization, in *Mithridates*, vol. iii, pl. 1, p. 598.) The Omaguas or Enaguas called themselves also Aguas (*Acunha*, p. 24). For this reason, no doubt, the province of Papamene, or of the Omaguas, bore the name of *Dit-Agua*. (Fray Pedro Simon, p. 340.)